The Secret Knowledge of Grown-Ups

By David Wisniewski

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 8-9)** The truth must be told to kids!

ACTOR 2: For too long, for centuries in fact, it's been covered over, hidden, impossible to find.

ACTOR 1: A conspiracy, an organized silence by generations of grown-ups, has kept the truth from millions of children.

ACTOR 2: And what is this truth, you ask.

ACTOR 1: Simply this: The reasons grown-ups tell you to do things are not true!

ACTOR 2: Eat your vegetables, they say. They're good for you.

ACTOR 1: NONSENSE!

ACTOR 2: Comb your hair, they say. It keeps it neat.

ACTOR 2: POPPYCOCK! There are far mor sinister, truly macabre reasons for these seemingly innocent requests.

ACTOR 1: Over the last three years, [we've] gathered as much information as [we] could: crisscrossing the country in clever, impenetrable disguises . . .

ACTOR 2: Breaking into the secret files kept by hundreds of grown-ups . . .

ACTOR 1: Assembling the evidence.

ACTOR 2: And now . . . the truth!

INTRODUCTION

TOGETHER: *The Secret Knowledge of Grown-Ups by David Wisniewski*

TOGETHER: **(Pg 11-15)** GROWN-UP RULE #31

ACTOR 1: Eat Your Vegetables

ACTOR 2: Official Reason: They're good for you

ACTOR 1: The Truth: You don't eat vegetables because they're good for you. You eat vegetables to keep them under control!

ACTOR 2: Millions of years ago, vegetables ruled the earth.

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ACTOR 1: Big bunches of broccoli stomped through the jungles, followed by ferocious carrots and savage packs of peas.

ACTOR 2: And what were these terrible vegetables looking for? You guessed it . . .

ACTOR 1: People! Yes, these were meat-eating vegetables.

ACTOR 2: They terrorized the early humans, attacking without warning.

ACTOR 1: Our ancestors put up with this for centuries, living in drafty caves and getting nasty head colds. But then they discovered sticks and stones.

ACTOR 2: With these new weapons, humans began to defend themselves. At first, lone hunters would take on a single radish or green bean.

ACTOR 1: Eventually, groups of hunters tackled bigger game, like the saber-toothed asparagus and woolly cucumber.

ACTOR 2: By mixing these vanquished vegetables, primitive chefs invented

TOGETHER: SALAD!

ACTOR 1: More important, the discovery of fire allowed humans to cook their leafy foes.

ACTOR 2: This brought the Age of Vegetables to a close.

ACTOR 1: As the human race grew in size and intelligence, vegetables became smaller and dumber, devolving into the pathetic produce of gardens and grocery stores.

ACTOR 2: To prevent vegetables from ever regaining power, grown-ups eat them.

ACTOR 1: They don't like the flavor any more than you do, but it keeps the little horrors fearful and demoralized. It's a simple way to protect modern civilization.

ACTOR 2: Besides, which would you rather do: Eat vegetables or be eaten by vegetables?

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 17-21)** [And what about] GROWN-UP RULE #37

TOGETHER: Drink Plenty of Milk

ACTOR 2: Official Reason: It's good for you

ACTOR 1: The Truth: Yes, milk is packed with vitamins and protein, but that's not why parents want you to drink it. The real reason is . . .

TOGETHER: TO STOP OUR ATOMIC COWS FROM EXPLODING!

ACTOR 2: Kids have been told that millions of cows produce our country's milk. That's not true.

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ACTOR 1: At this moment, only five giant cows do all the work. The other are decoys made of plywood and old box springs.

ACTOR 2: One of these colossal cows is Flossie. *(MOO!)* Eighty feet tall, she provides the daily milk supply for Utah, Nevada, Wyoming, and Colorado.

ACTOR 1: Flossie is kept under tight security at a secret air-force base, right next to the hangar where they stack all the banged-up flying saucers.

ACTOR 2: Flossie's size is no accident. In the 1950s, our government was afraid that the Russians would develop the first atomic cow and flood the market with Communist milk.

ACTOR 1: To prevent this, American scientists fed Flossie and her friends radioactive hay.

ACTOR 2: The experiment worked great. But Flossie can't be turned off. The milk just keeps coming.

ACTOR 1: [Now], government officials are very happy that all this milk is available. However, there is one crisis the government can't prepare for: kids ***NOT*** drinking milk.

ACTOR 2: If that happened, Flossie would have to hold it *(both actors cross their legs)*

ACTOR 1: Getting bigger and bigger until

TOGETHER: NUCLEAR MILKDOWN!

ACTOR 2: Such a catastrophe forever scars the landscape between the Arizona towns of Flagstaff and Winslow.

ACTOR 1: A huge crater is all that remains of Doris, the only atomic cow that ever exploded.

ACTOR 2: When kids felt the ground shake and saw the curdled cloud of dairy products form over the desert back in 1962, they were told that a meteor had hit the local Tastee Freeze.

ACTOR 1: Now you know better. So drink your milk!

ACTOR 2: **(Pg 37-41)** [Which brings us to] GROWN-UP RULE #62

TOGETHER: Don't jump on your bed. *(jumping enthusiastically)*

ACTOR 2: Official Reasons: You'll break it. You might get hurt.

ACTOR 1: The Truth: Yes, it's possible to break your bed if you jump on it. And it's possible you might bet hurt if you fall off. But you'll definitely get hurt . . .

TOGETHER: IF YOU WAKE UP THE MATTRESS!

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ACTOR 2: You see, mattresses aren't just big lifeless rectangles crammed with stuffing.

ACTOR 1: They are active wooly creatures raised on farms in Scotland. After growing to adulthood, the mattresses start a long period of hibernation.

ACTOR 2: Undisturbed by noise and handling, they are rounded up, sorted by size, and sold to stores.

ACTOR 1: Then they end up in your bedroom, where they snooze peacefully year after year.

ACTOR 2: Unless you jump on them!

ACTOR 1: Fortunately, today's mattresses are very difficult to wake up. That wasn't the case with their hardy ancestors.

ACTOR 2: One night, about 1040 AD, the Scottish King, Malcolm the Upset, wandered the moors, trying to get over eating haggis --

ACTOR 2: A real humdinger of a national dish – a pudding made from the heart, lungs and liver of a sheep! No, I am NOT making this up!

ACTOR 2: Malcolm stumbled upon a wild hibernating mountain mattress, upon which he slept soundly for the first time in many years. He realized that the wild mattress was more comfortable than the boulder he usually slept on.

ACTOR 1: King Malcolm brought the mattress home and began breeding it. Soon he was giving mattresses as gifts to other kinds and queens.

ACTOR 2: Unfortunately, these feral mattresses woke up and started slinging royalty around!

ACTOR 1: This was very bad for King Malcolm, who spent the rest of his life in prison, eating haggis. *(EWWWWW!)*

ACTOR 2: The modern domestic mattress [has a mild] disposition and long hibernation period.

ACTOR 1: Still, it's not a good idea to jump on your bed. The mattress might be hard to wake up, but it's not impossible.

ACTOR 2: And, for goodness sake, don't play the bagpipes near it!

ACTOR 1: **(Pg 49-52)** [And finally] GROWN-UP RULE #82 - Don't pick your nose.

ACTOR 2: Official Reason: It's gross and disgusting

ACTOR 1: The Truth: Actually, picking your nose is gross and disgusting. However, that's not

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the real reason, which is . . .

TOGETHER: TO STOP YOUR BRAIN FROM DEFLATING!

ACTOR 2: The air pipeline that keeps your brain inflated runs past the nostrils to a vast pumping station inside your head.

ACTOR 1: An intruding digit will certainly dent the pipeline. It may even poke a hole in it, causing an outburst of air called

ACTOR 2: *(Sneezes)* In technical language, a sneeze.

ACTOR 1: If you can't give up this nasty habit right away, at least be familiar with the warning signs of brain deflation:

ACTOR 2: A faint hissing noise *(noise by Actor 1)*

ACTOR 1: A sound like a balloon let loose in a bathtub *(noise by Actor 2)*

ACTOR 2: Silence, and a floppy rolling noise when you tilt your head *(noise by Actor 1)*

ACTOR 1: Although this baggy brain still works, it won't absorb much new information, so it pays to fix it before the next spelling test. Here's the simple way . . .

ACTOR 2: Shine a flashlight up your nose *(demonstrates)*

ACTOR 1: Just as a plant tuns toward the sun, your brain will be attracted to the light and flop over to it. Your brain will then be centered over the pipeline, ready for inflation.

ACTOR 2: Hold your nose and hum. *(demonstrates)*

ACTOR 1: Finger pressure stabilizes the pipeline. Humming entertains the mending muscles as they drive bulldozers around to fix things up.

ACTOR 2: There is a more difficult way to reinflate your brain, but it requires four years of college, one pair of pliers, and three feet of lead pipe.

ACTOR 1: Hundreds of grown-up rules remain. The truth must be told about them ALL!

ACTOR 2: *(reaction to an unseen noise - whispers)* But they're on [our] trail. I hear them coming!

TOGETHER: THE GROWN-UPS!!!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier
2023 National Qualifier - MS

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